



Generous On Paper, Quiet On the Calendar

Interviewing Staff After the Move to Unlimited Annual Leave

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Background

A fixed annual-leave allocation gives staff a number to plan against. Employers replacing it with an unlimited policy remove that number — but not the workload, the roster, or the unspoken sense of whose turn it is to go.

Aims

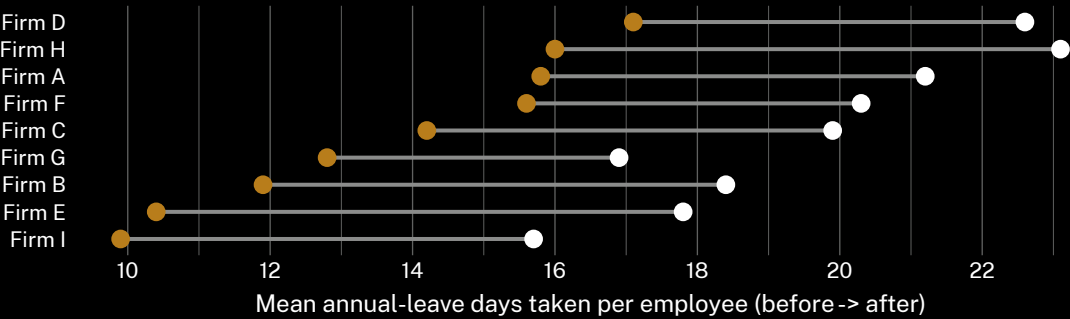
- Track how staff decide when it's "their turn" to book leave once no allocation exists
- Compare days taken per employee before and after each firm's policy switch
- Catalogue the informal cues staff substitute for a stated cap

Methods

- 41 staff · 9 firms that dropped a fixed allocation for an unlimited policy within the past 3 years · semi-structured interviews
- 18 months of matched HR leave-taken records spanning each firm's switch date
- Transcripts thematically coded independently by two researchers; disagreements adjudicated blind to the leave-taken figures

Results

Leave taken per employee fell at every firm in the eighteen months after the cap was removed, tracking not workload but how visibly colleagues were already away.



Mean annual-leave days taken per employee fell from 19.5 to 13.7 across nine firms in the eighteen months after each retired its fixed allocation for an unlimited policy (n = 41 staff interviews matched to HR leave records).

Discussion & conclusions

Staff describe checking the shared calendar before booking, not the policy itself — waiting for a visibly quiet week, or for a colleague to go first. Removing the number did not remove the limit; it moved the limit into a social calculation nobody was assigned to referee. Next: whether publishing an anonymised days-taken average restores the missing number, or simply gives staff a new one to under-shoot.

References

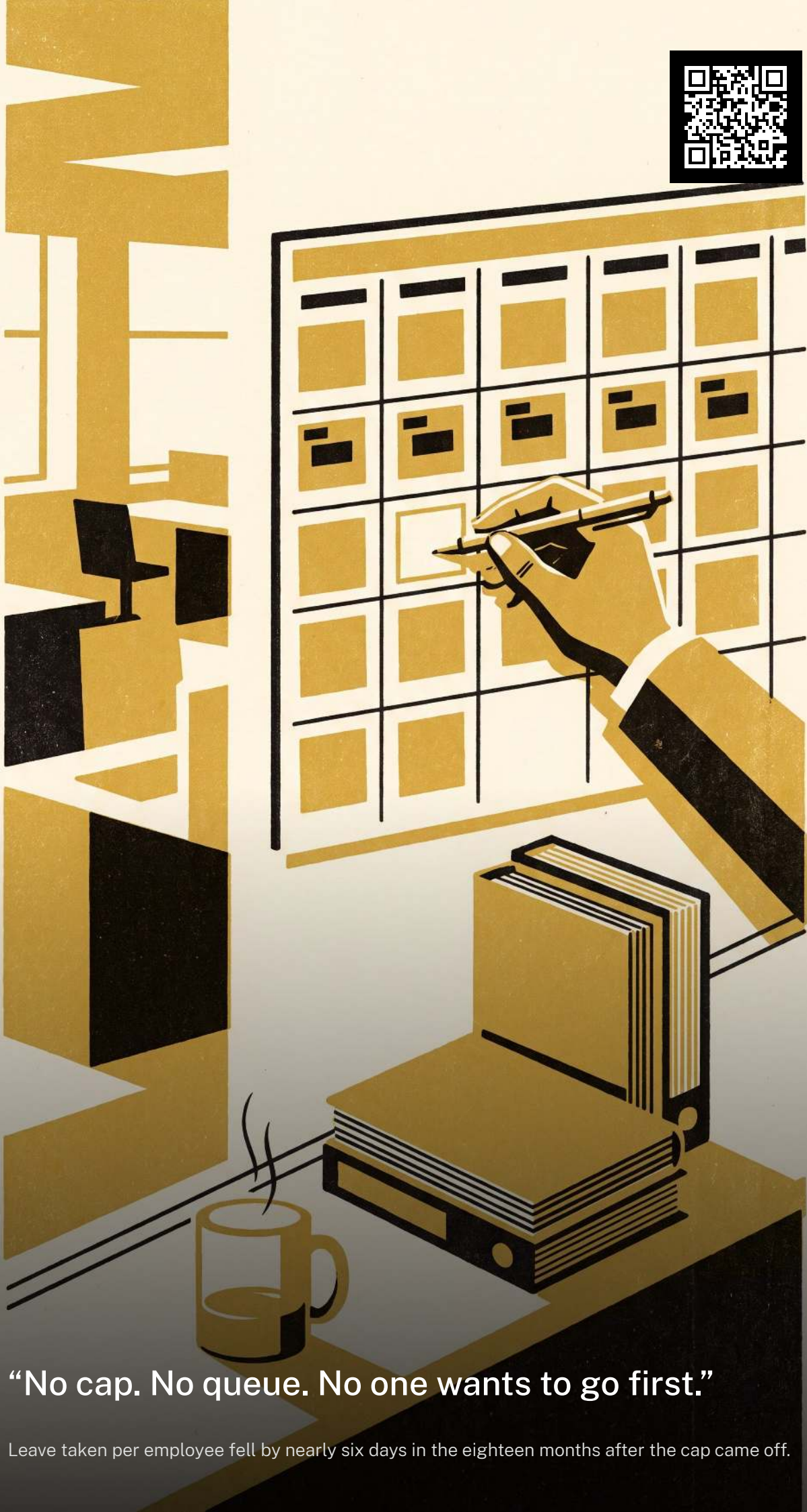
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We thank the nine participating firms' people-and-culture teams for matched leave records.

Interview protocol approved under General Human Ethics 2025/188; leave records de-identified to firm level only.

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“No cap. No queue. No one wants to go first.”

Leave taken per employee fell by nearly six days in the eighteen months after the cap came off.